

The circle of fifths

The circle of fifths is a diagram that shows the relationship between the various major and minor keys. Understanding this diagram will help you remember how many sharps or flats a key signature has.

SEE ALSO

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◀ 60–61 Major scales

◀ 62–63 Minor scales

◀ 64–67 Keys

Harmony

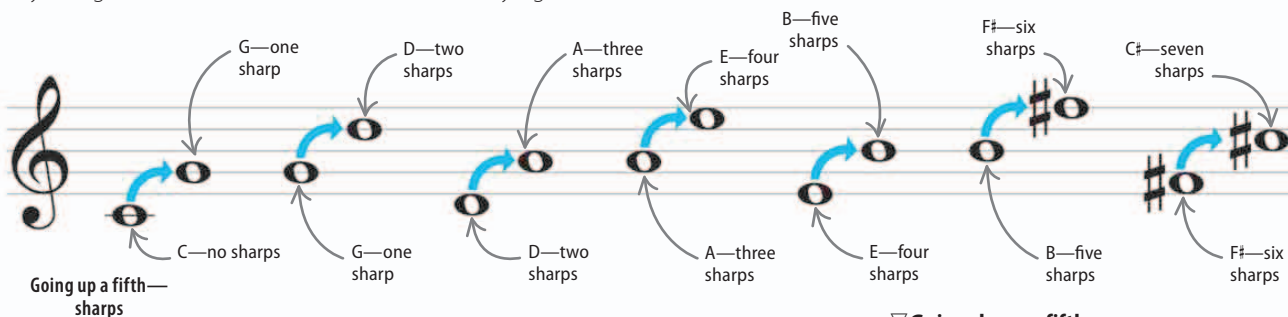
118–119 ▶

How does it work with major keys?

The circle of fifths illustrates the relationship between major keys that are a fifth apart. Starting from C major, as the keynote goes up a fifth, a sharp is added to the key signature of the new key. As the keynote goes down a fifth, a flat is added to the key signature.

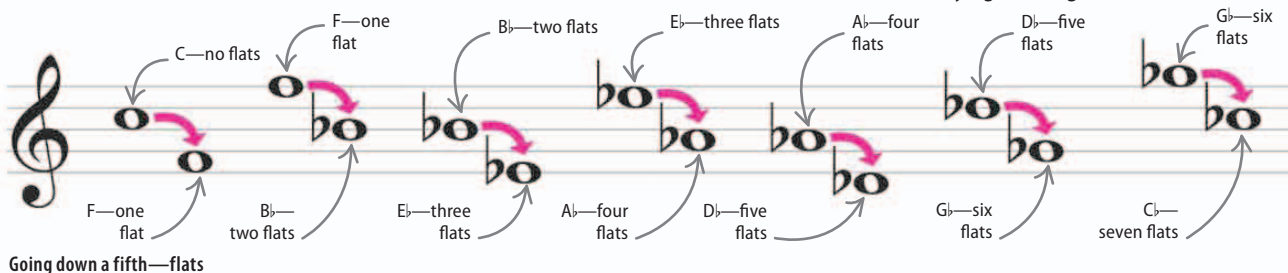
▽ Going up a fifth

As the keynotes of the major keys shown on the staff below move up a fifth, their key signatures gain another sharp.



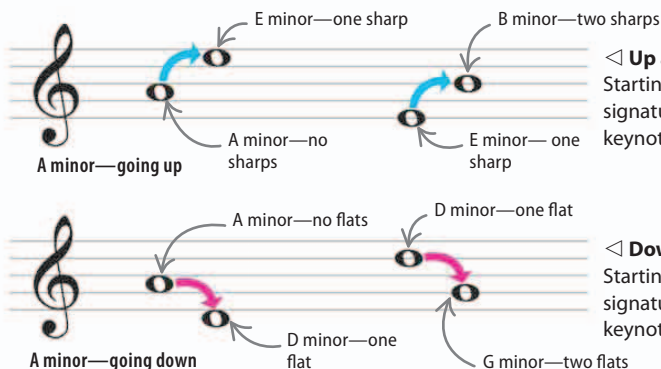
▽ Going down a fifth

As the keynotes of the major keys shown on the staff below move down a fifth, their key signatures gain another flat.



What about minor keys?

Because minor keys share a key signature with their relative major, their key signatures gain a sharp when the keynote goes up a fifth and gain a flat when the keynote goes down a fifth in the same way as major keys.



◁ Up a fifth

Starting from A minor, the key signature gains a sharp as the keynote moves up a fifth.

◁ Down a fifth

Starting from A minor, the key signature gains a flat as the keynote moves down a fifth.